

Marco Polo's India

(1292 CE)

Returning home from China in 1292 CE, Marco Polo arrives on the Coromandel Coast of India in a typical merchant ship with over sixty cabins and up to 300 crewmen.[1] He enters the kingdom of the Tamil Pandyas near modern Thanjavur, where, according to custom, 'the king and his barons and everyone else all sit on the earth'. He asks why they 'do not seat themselves more honorably'. The king replies, 'To sit on the earth is honorable enough, because we were made from the earth and to the earth we must return.' Marco Polo documented this episode in his famous book, *The Travels*, as part of his rich social portrait of coastal India.[2]

The climate is so hot that all men and women wear nothing but a loincloth, including the king—except his is studded with rubies, sapphires, emeralds and other gems. Marco calls this 'the richest and most splendid province in the world', one that, together with Ceylon, produces 'most of the pearls and gems that are to be found in the world'. Merchants and traders abound, the king takes pride in not holding himself above the law of the land and people travel the highways safely with their valuables in the cool of the night air. In this kingdom, justice 'is very strictly administered to those who commit homicide or theft or any other crime'.